

Epistemic Foundations

Phil 101 · Day 5

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Where we are

Recap

Last week we talked about this model of learning.

1. Something **perceives** the external world.
2. Something **processes** what perception delivers.

And we split the processing into **safe** processing, where the premises guarantee the conclusion, and **risky** processing, where they don't.

What Grue showed

Thursday's puzzle was about the risky half. There isn't a simple rule getting from your past evidence to what will happen in the future.

You need to make some substantive assumptions about what's a real feature of the world, and that's not easy to automate.

Today we change the question. Last week was *how should you reason from what you have*; this week *when is what you have any good?*

The easy case

You look out the window. You see that it's raining. You believe it's raining.

Here are two questions about this:

1. What goes on under the hood when you do this?
2. Why is the resulting belief justified, if indeed it is?

Justification

The word

We'll use **justified** as our generic term for beliefs that are good to have.

We won't distinguish it from *reasonable*, *rational*, *sensible*, or other similar terms.

Maybe there are differences between these terms, language rarely includes precise synonyms, but we'll leave those differences for another course.

Two ways to have a reason

Here's one intuitive thought: Justified beliefs are those backed by **reasons**.

Todd Long, in the reading, separates two things that both get called reasons.

Epistemic reason

A consideration that makes the belief **likely to be true**.

Practical reason

A consideration that makes you **better off** for holding it.

Telling them apart

Nomy Arpaly, a philosopher at Brown, illustrates the difference with this story.

A person has received a worrying diagnosis, and their doctor has run a lot of tests, they are now meeting to discuss them.

- ▶ Patient: Is there any reason to hope?
- ▶ Doctor: Yes.
- ▶ Patient: Great, what do the tests show?
- ▶ Doctor: Oh the tests were not good, but patients who are hopeful have better outcomes, so you should remain hopeful for that reason.

Which one we care about

The patient here should be rather upset with the doctor; she's changed the subject.

When we ask whether there are reasons to believe something, or even think it not impossible, we are looking for reasons that make it likely to be true.

Epistemology is about those reasons, and that's our focus here.

The regress

Questions that come naturally to children

For any belief you have, even one as simple as *It's raining*, a child can (and for some children, often does) ask this question:

Why do you believe that?

You answer with some reason. But, and here's the catch, they can ask it again.

Three ways it can go

Ask enough times and there are only three things that can happen.

1. It never stops. The chain of reasons runs on forever.
2. It comes back on itself. You end up citing something you already used.
3. It stops. You hit something you believe, but not on the basis of anything further.

Each of these looks bad. This badness has been recognised as a problem, at least back to Roman times, for our justification.

The first two

Call the first **infinetism**: as long as every step has a justification, you're good, even if the chain goes on forever. The obvious complaint is that you are finite. You have not had infinitely many thoughts and you're not going to.

Call the second **coherentism**: your beliefs support each other and nothing is foundational. The obvious complaint is that circular reasoning is a paradigm of what we call *irrational*. Also, how coherent my mind is looks like a *global* property of my mind, so it applies equally to all my beliefs. But I have some beliefs that are sensible, and some that are stupid.

It stops

Call this **foundationalism**. Some beliefs are justified, but not by other beliefs. Everything else rests on them.

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Foundationalists maintain that some beliefs are properly basic and that the rest of one's beliefs inherit their epistemic status (knowledge or justification) in virtue of receiving proper support from the basic beliefs.

The two kinds of belief

Basic

Justified, but not by any other belief you hold.

Non-basic

Justified by other beliefs, ultimately by basic ones.

Foundationalism is the view that the structure of justified belief has this shape.

What could be basic?

The natural first answer, for creatures like us, is **perception**.

We see that it's raining, and that's the regress stopper.

Let's look at this further.

Perception as Basic

Descartes's demand

If these things are the foundation, they store all the supports and all the plumbing and everything else, they better be sturdy.

What we'll call **Classical foundationalism** requires basic beliefs to be infallible, or indubitable, or incorrigible. Something you cannot be wrong about, or cannot doubt, or cannot be corrected on. (Or maybe all three of these)

René Descartes is the most famous defender of this kind of view, and we'll come back to him.

Does perception pass?

So: is *It's raining* something you cannot be wrong about?

No. The problem is perception gets things wrong.

Visual Illusions

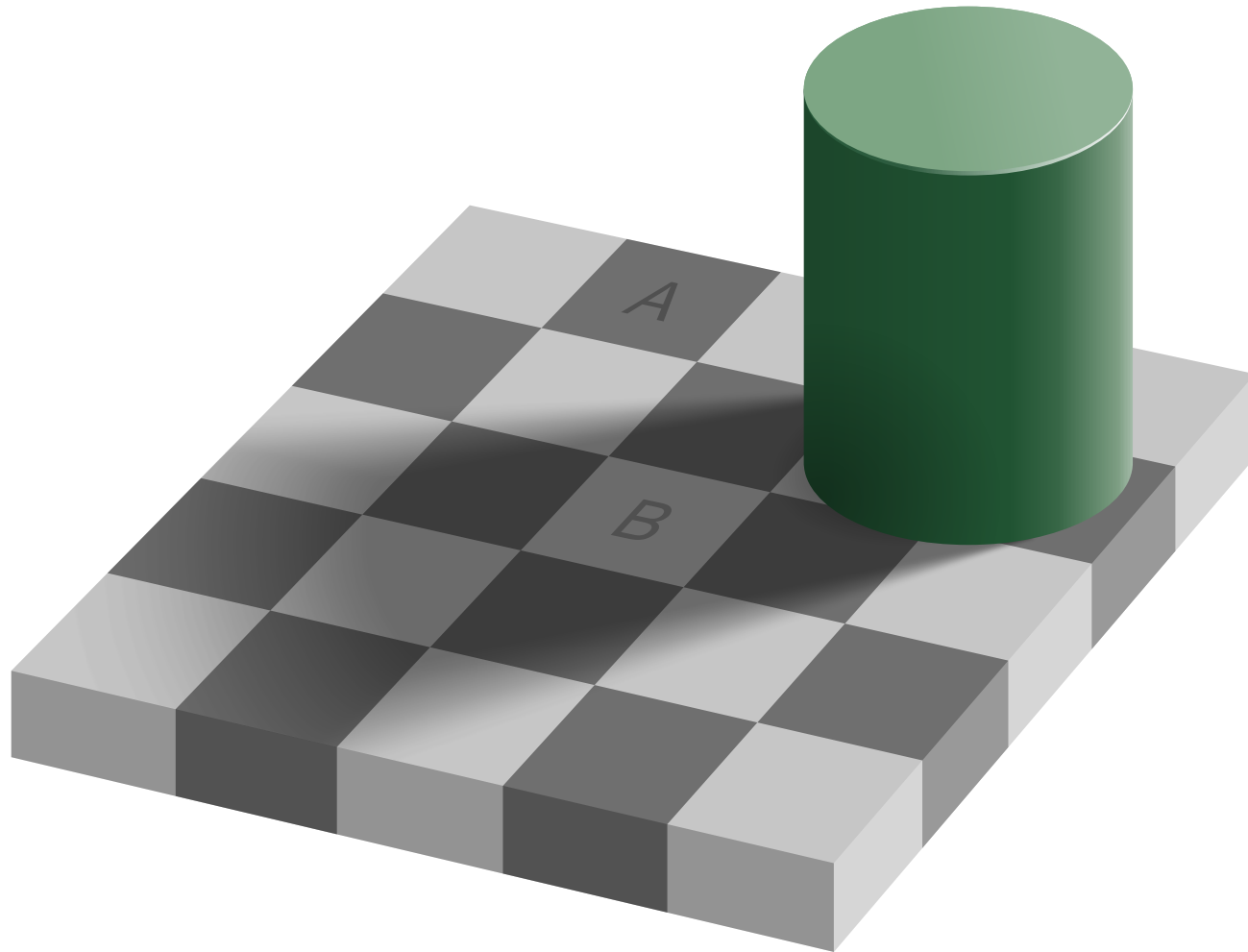


Figure 1: A and B are the same shade

iClicker

OK, time to test the iClicker software. Here's a very quick poll. (By 'poll' I mean you get points just for answering. But this is a test week, so there aren't points anyway!)

Which square is actually darker?

- A. It's A
- B. It's B
- C. They're the same color, they just look different.

Why are we back to illusions?

On Day 3 this was evidence *for* the two-part model. The fact that perception makes mistakes is a reason to think it is a separate system to processing.

Today it's a problem. If perception makes mistakes, and it just delivers the starting points, then the whole system might be rotten.

The retreat inwards

There is a standard move here.

What's basic isn't *square A is darker than square B*, but rather *square A looks darker to me*.

Two Problems

1. Perhaps there could be illusions about how you *feel*. This is tricky, but perhaps possible.
2. It's the wrong *kind* of thing.

If my starting points are facts about what's going on inside my head, I need a reason to draw inferences from this to the outside world, and the attempts to do this have not been spectacular successes.

There is also a problem about how evidence is shareable on this picture, which will be in the background when we get to testimony.

Modest foundationalism

The other option is to ask less.

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Modest foundationalism permits basic beliefs that are fallible, corrigible, or dubitable.

Basic beliefs can be wrong. They just have to be good enough to build on. That's Long's **fallibilism**: a belief can be justified and still be false.

This raises many more puzzles, but let's set it aside and turn to something more practical.

How many sources?

What's basic?

In the last section I discussed this claim:

- ▶ Perception delivers basic beliefs, ones that are justified but not in virtue of something else.

Even if that's correct, it raises many more questions.

1. Is *perception* a single source, or should we divide it up. Perhaps we should divide it into Aristotle's five senses (vision, hearing, taste, touch, smell), or into something more modern.
2. Are there any other basic sources?

Examples

- ▶ Is memory a third thing, or storage attached to the other two?
- ▶ Is taking somebody's word for it a way of processing, a second way of taking things in, or something else?

Pramāṇa

We've mainly been talking about European and American philosophers so far, but until recently there was very little in this 'Western' (more precisely Mediterranean/North Atlantic) tradition on this question.

But this question was really important to South Asian philosophy for a long time.¹

A **pramāṇa** is a means of knowledge.²

¹Possibly 'Indian philosophy' would be a better name here, but I don't want to leave the impression that this was all done by people living inside the present-day borders of India.

²A more literal translation might be 'proof', but 'means of knowledge' is closer to what we're interested in.

How many?

There were several **schools** of philosophy in South Asia. That's not unusual, this kind of division is common in lots of traditions, both as something that philosophers themselves use, and as something historians impose to make sense of a messy field.

What's distinctive here is that often what defined the different schools were disputes about how many pramāṇa there are, and what they are.

Candidates

- ▶ Perception
- ▶ Inference
- ▶ Analogy, understood as distinct from narrowly logical inference
- ▶ Testimony
- ▶ Derivation from circumstances, roughly inference to sensible explanation
- ▶ Inference from non-perception, e.g., I don't see an elephant so there is no elephant here.

What's at stake

If a school didn't endorse a method, that might mean one of two things.

1. They didn't trust it at all. Some of the riskier ones, like 'derivation from circumstances' were treated this way.
2. They didn't think it was a *distinct* method. So maybe it does work, but it's just an application of other methods.

The more austere schools, like the ones that defended the view that gets picked up in Sherlock Holmes and many modern applications that it's just perception plus inference, often aim to show that the other methods are just applications of these two.

Going forward

Thursday

Memory, which is the odd one out on every list we've seen.

You are carrying around a very large number of beliefs, and for almost none of them can you say where you got them. Thursday's question is whether they're any good.

Then testimony next Tuesday. In 1927 an Indian philosopher, Dhirendra Mohan Datta¹ published a paper in *Mind* (the leading English philosophy journal) arguing that testimony is a distinct source. This is a characteristic view of the Nyāya school, and his arguments draw heavily from that tradition.

¹The name on the article was 'Dhirendron Mohon Datta', but I'm very confident it's the person who primarily published as 'Dhirendra Mohan Datta'. I don't know if the journal erred, or he changed the preferred way of presenting his name in English between 1927 and his more famous later works.